

IRELAND START-UP ENTREPRENEUR PROGRAMME (STEP) — APPLICATION

Submitted via official STEP application channel, Irish Naturalisation & Immigration Service

Applicant company: BETONIQ WEST LTD — trading as ZerôPâ■ Money

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Company registration: RC 1496603 | Abuja, FCT, Nigeria

Submission channel: Official STEP application email, Irish Naturalisation & Immigration Service (ISD)

Date: August 26, 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

1.4 billion people globally are unbanked or severely underbanked — 38 million of them in Nigeria alone. ZerôPâ■ Money is the world's first offline-first, uncapped NFC contactless payment protocol, enabling merchants anywhere to accept fully authenticated digital payments with zero internet connectivity.

BETONIQ WEST LTD is seeking to establish a European operating base in Ireland under the Start-up Entrepreneur Programme (STEP), using Ireland as the company's EU headquarters for engineering, compliance, and international expansion into markets with unreliable connectivity infrastructure — not limited to Africa, but genuinely global (disaster-response corridors, rural regions, and developed-market outage scenarios worldwide).

THE INNOVATION

ZerôPâ■ Money uses a patent-pending four-layer cryptographic architecture — NFC (ISO 14443-A/B), PUF hardware authentication, ECC P-256 offline signing, and a distance-bounding anti-relay protocol — to process, authenticate, and queue transactions entirely offline, then batch-settle them once connectivity is restored. The protocol has been formally verified via TLA+ model checking (437 states, 0 violations).

HIGH POTENTIAL START-UP (HPSU) CRITERIA

Innovative product/service: ZerôPâ■ Money is a structural breakthrough in payment infrastructure, not an incremental improvement — it removes connectivity dependency, the single largest barrier to global financial inclusion.

Job creation potential: The Ireland base is planned to build a core engineering, compliance, and European business development team, targeting 10+ roles within 3-4 years as the EU expansion phase (West Africa Phase 2 and Global Replication Phase 3, detailed in our FID and investor materials) scales.

Export/international sales potential: €1M+ turnover within 3-4 years is realistic given the signed Paystack merchant agreement (July 14, 2026) as a live commercial proof point, plus the PSP-agnostic architecture that allows rapid multi-market rollout (Ghana, Sierra Leone, Senegal already mapped for Phase 2).

Funding: Minimum €50,000 in funding is available to support the Ireland establishment, sourced from founder equity and the active grant/investment pipeline currently in progress (FID €3.2M application, Founders Fund Africa, and other channels detailed on request).

FOUNDER CREDENTIALS

Tom Ugbodaga — Shareholder & CEO, BETONIQ WEST LTD. MSc Computer Systems Security (University of Gloucestershire — England, 2011). Dissertation: NFC Contactless Technology for Financial Payments (Merit Class) — the direct technical foundation of ZerôPâ■ Money's architecture today.

This is a 15-year research commercialisation: the founder holds a postgraduate degree in the exact scientific discipline — NFC security and applied cryptography — that underpins this innovation.

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WHY IRELAND

Ireland offers EU market access, a strong fintech regulatory environment, and a talent base well suited to scaling a hardware-rooted cryptographic payments protocol across Europe and beyond. STEP would allow BETONIQ WEST LTD to establish this EU base directly, with Ireland serving as the springboard for European partnerships, compliance frameworks, and connectivity-poor market deployments across the continent.

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